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Client Behavior in Counseling and Therapy Sessions: Development of a Pantheoretical Measure

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The purpose of this study was to revise the Hill et al. (1981) Client Verbal Response Category System. The client behavior system (CBS), which includes 8 nominal, mutually exclusive categories, was created. Psychologists indicated that clients generally are more productively involved when engaged in cognitive-behavioral exploration, affective exploration, insight, and changes than in resistance, agreement, requests, and recounting. When the CBS was used to rate predominant client behavior in middle sessions of 8 cases of brief individual therapy, adequate interjudge agreement was found, with cognitive-behavioral exploration occurring most frequently. Client experiencing and client ratings of helpfulness differed across CBS categories, suggesting concurrent validity for the measure. In a second study, 9 interviewer queries elicited different interviewee behaviors in 39 structured interviews, providing evidence of construct validity.

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To understand the interaction between counselors and clients, researchers need measures of client behavior. A measure of client behavior can aid in describing and evaluating client behavior, ascertaining the ways in which clients respond to counselor interventions, and assessing the ways in which clients change over the course of treatment.

In considering the importance of client behavior in counseling and therapy, it is puzzling that a single measure or even a single type of measure has not emerged as the standard in the field. In measuring counselor behavior, in contrast, response modes have been widely accepted as a standard type of measure, with several different versions created by different researchers (cf. Elliott et al., 1987). In contrast, several different types of measures of client behavior, most of which were developed from single theoretical perspectives (e.g., client experiencing: Klein, Mathieu-Coughlan, & Kiesler, 1986; client vocal quality: Rice & Kerr, 1986; client perceptual processing: Toukmanian, 1986; interactional patterns: Benjamin, 1979; and response modes: Snyder, 1945; Stiles, 1986; Hill et al., 1981). Although these measures are useful for specific research purposes, pantheoretical measures are needed so that client behavior can be studied across theoretical approaches to determine the effects of different therapeutic interventions.

Hill and O'Grady (1985) developed a generic model for describing the counseling process. Briefly, this model specifies that counselor intentions lead counselors to select particular response modes to use in their interventions, which in turn create specific reactions in clients, who then select their behaviors accordingly. Measures have been developed for each of these dimensions (Hill, 1992), including the Client Verbal Response Category System (Hill, 1986; Hill et al., 1981).

Hill et al.'s (1981) system includes nine nominal, mutually exclusive categories: simple responses, requests, description, experiencing, insight, discussion of plans, discussion of client-counselor relationship, silence, and other. Although Hill et al. obtained high interjudge agreement using this system (mean kappa = .92) and found predicted relationships with counselor interventions, there are several problems with the system. First, most of the responses fell into the description (54%) and simple responses (25%) categories, which resulted in a restricted characterization of the therapy process. Particularly problematic, the system seems to focus most on behaviors valued in client-centered or psychodynamic therapies, such as experiencing or insight, and to disregard behaviors valued more in cognitive or behavioral therapies, such as cognitive or behavioral exploration.

Second, there are no categories for describing client resistance. Given that clients sometimes have difficulty engaging in therapeutic tasks, either because of their own issues or because of ineffective counselor interventions, inclusion of resistant behaviors in a measure of client behavior is important. Chamberlain, Patterson, Reid, Kavanagh, and Forgatch (1984) developed the Therapy Process Code to measure resistant behavior in families. They found that families who dropped out of treatment had more instances of resistance than families who completed treatment and that agency-referred families had more resistance than self-referred families. Patterson and Forgatch (1985) found that client resistance was higher when therapists were teaching and confronting and lower when therapists were supporting or facilitating. Furthermore, resistance was highest in the middle phase of treatment relative to early and late phases of treatment

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(Chamberlain et al., 1984; Chamberlain & Ray, 1988). Chamberlain and Ray (1988) also found that resistance by mothers was negatively correlated with therapist liking of mothers, indicating that therapists disliked resistant mothers. Also, children of more resistant mothers had poorer treatment outcomes. Thus, the research on client resistance in family treatment suggests that resistance is an important behavior that needs to be included in a comprehensive measure of client verbal behavior.

Third, the Hill et al. (1981) system includes categories that are at different conceptual levels. Simple responses and silence categories do not seem to be conceptually similar to the overt verbal categories. Simple responses (e.g., "Mmhmm") are often conversation-maintaining devices, rather than overt verbal communication. Silence, which can have many different functions in therapy, is clearly not a form of verbal communication. Although both simple responses and silence can be very important client behaviors in counseling, they do not convey what the client is doing in the same manner that overt behaviors such as insight or requests do. Furthermore, the category of discussion of the client–counselor relationship seems to be more global than do the other categories. For example, when talking about the relationship, the client could be involved in description, experiencing, or insight. From a methodological standpoint, measures should assess behaviors at the same level of abstraction (Greenberg & Pinsof, 1986).

Fourth, the Hill et al. (1981) system uses transcripts to code client behaviors, thus ignoring nonverbal and paralinguistic cues that would be available from use of videotapes. Because nonverbal and paralinguistic behaviors are important in communication (cf. Harper, Wiens, & Matarazzo, 1978), the lack of attention to nonverbal cues is a serious limitation of the Hill et al. system.

Finally, the Hill et al. (1981) system relies on unit (sentence) judgments of client behaviors, which present a molecular analysis of what the client is saying. However, counselors probably respond to the most predominant or central aspect of what the client communicates in an entire speaking turn. Moreover, the use of multiple behaviors within speaking turns results in a lack of independence of data in statistical analyses. Hill, Carter, and O'Farrell (1983) tried to address this issue by examining the first two units (sentences) of the speaking turn, but that approach still missed the essential or predominant message. O'Farrell, Hill, and Patton (1986) used predominant judgments rather than unit judgments but did not report interjudge agreement levels for these predominant judgments.

Our overall purpose was to revise the Hill et al. (1981) measure by correcting several of its deficiencies (adding cognitive–behavioral exploration and resistance; eliminating simple responses, discussion of counselor–client relationship, and silence; adding categories of nonverbal and paralinguistic cues and requiring the use of videotapes for the judgment process; and adding predominant judgments). We first revised the system, creating the new client behavior system (CBS) and then conducted two studies to examine the interjudge agreement and validity of the CBS.

Revision of the Client Behavior System

In revising the Hill et al. (1981) system, we followed several guidelines: (a) categories should be nominal and mutually exclusive, (b) categories should represent the range of possible client behaviors in therapy, (c) categories should cover the range of client behaviors that would be expected from different theoretical perspectives, and (d) categories should all be at the same level of abstraction. We revised the Hill et al. categories on the basis of our examination of other systems (Chamberlain and Ray, 1988; Klein et al., 1986; Mahrer, Nadler, Sterner, & White, 1989; McCullough, 1990; Rice & Kerr, 1986; Snyder, 1945; Stiles, 1986).

The preliminary categories were revised several times as judges applied them to videotapes of counseling sessions (other than those used in Study 1). After several iterations of refining our categories and applying them to new sessions, the present eight-category system was developed (See Appendix).

We asked 16 (9 female, 7 male) post-PhD counseling and clinical psychologists to examine the final version of the CBS. Psychologists who examined the CBS thought that it was clear, complete, and adequate for measuring what we set out to measure. They suggested minor wording changes for the categories, which we incorporated. Thus, the psychologists provided us with evidence of face and content validity for the CBS.

To gain an overall sense of the valence of the categories, we also asked the 16 psychologists to rate how involved and productive clients generally are when engaged in each of the eight CBS behaviors, using a 9-point scale ranging from *totally uninvolved in therapy and not working productively* (1) to *totally involved in therapy and working productively* (9). Means and standard deviations of ratings for each of the CBS categories are presented in Table 1. A repeated measures multivariate analysis of variance used to test differences between categories was significant with Pillai's trace $F(7, 9) = 16.29$, $p < .001$, indicating overall differences between categories. Because of the limited sample size, all post hoc comparisons could not be computed. Instead, we compared ratings on the first four categories (resistance, agreement, request, recounting) with ratings on the final four categories (cognitive–behavioral exploration, affective exploration, insight, changes) because we had hypothesized differences between these clusters on the basis of past research (Hill, Helms, Tichenor, et al., 1988). A post hoc orthogonal contrast was significant, $F(1, 15) = 119.24$, $p < .001$, indicating that

Table 1
Ratings by Psychologists of Client Involvement and Productivity for the Client Behavior System Categories

Category	*M*	*SD*
Resistance	3.31	2.09
Agreement	4.41	1.16
Request	5.25	1.40
Recounting	3.66	1.48
Cog–beh exploration	7.16	1.40
Affective exploration	8.06	0.79
Insight	7.91	0.93
Changes	7.16	1.34

Note. Cog–beh = Cognitive or behavioral. Ratings of client involvement and productivity were made by 16 post-PhD psychologists on a 9-point scale, ranging from *totally uninvolved and not working productively* (1) to *totally involved and working productively* (9).

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psychologists viewed the final 4 categories as reflecting more productive behaviors than the first 4 categories.

Study 1

The first purpose of Study 1 was to examine the interjudge reliability for each of the categories, and the overlap between categories. Reliability was determined for both response units (grammatical sentences) and predominant (speaking turn) judgments. We used predominant judgments in our data analyses because (a) they presented a more global picture of what the counselor responds to in client behavior in a speaking turn than did unit judgments and (b) use of predominant judgments addresses the problem of lack of independence of unit data for statistical analyses. Thus, obtaining adequate reliability for predominant judgments was critical. The second purpose was to describe client behavior in actual therapy sessions to provide some initial normative data.

The third purpose was to establish convergent validity by comparing categorizations on the CBS with ratings on the Client Experiencing Scale (Klein, Mathieu, Gendlin, & Kiesler, 1970), both measures of judge-rated client behavior. We expected that higher levels of experiencing would be related to the more productive CBS categories (cognitive–behavioral exploration, affective exploration, insight, therapeutic changes). The fourth purpose was to establish construct validity by comparing CBS categorizations to client ratings of the helpfulness of the preceding counselor interventions (using archival data). We expected that when clients rated counselor interventions as more helpful, they would engage in more productive CBS behaviors.

Using the CBS, four trained judges coded one middle session from each of eight cases from an archival data set (Hill, 1989). Middle sessions were used because we thought that they would contain a wide range of client behaviors.

Method

Data Set

The data set for this study consisted of eight cases of brief therapy reported on elsewhere (Hill, 1989; Hill, Helms, Spiegel, & Tichenor, 1988; Hill, Helms, Tichenor, et al., 1988). The 8 (4 female, 4 male; 6 White, 2 Black) therapists averaged 46.38 (SD = 13.47) years of age, had an average of 18.50 (SD = 10.85) years of postdoctoral experience, and rated themselves, using 5-point Likert scales ranging from *low* (1) to *high* (5), on average as 3.75 (SD = 0.46) on psychoanalytic orientation, 2.62 (SD = 0.74) on humanistic orientation, and 2.50 (SD = 1.07) on behavioral theoretical orientation. The 8 female (6 White, 1 Arabic American, 1 Asian American) clients averaged 42.38 (SD = 9.41) years of age. All had elevated scores on the Depression and Psychasthenia subscales of the Minnesota Multiphasic Personality Inventory. Clients and therapists were unaware of the specific purposes of the study but were fully informed about all research procedures and signed consent forms before and after treatment.

This data set was chosen because it included ratings of client experiencing, as well as client ratings of the helpfulness of therapist interventions, both of which we used to validate the CBS. The Client Experiencing Scale (Klein et al., 1970; Klein, Mathieu-Coughlan, & Kiesler, 1986) is a 7-point scale used to describe a client's level of involvement in the therapy. In the Hill, Helms, Tichenor, et al. (1988) data set, six raters obtained an intraclass correlation (alpha) of 0.99 on two randomly selected sessions. The Helpfulness Scale (Elliott, 1985) is a 9-point Likert scale, ranging from *extremely unhelpful* (1) to *extremely helpful* (9), used by clients during a videotape review to rate therapist interventions.

Judges

Four women (3 White, 1 Hispanic; 3 master's-level students; 1 professor), all authors of the study, served as judges.

Measures

The CBS described above was used for this study. The CBS includes eight nominal, mutually exclusive categories: resistance, agreement, appropriate request, recounting, cognitive–behavioral exploration, affective exploration, insight, and therapeutic changes.

Procedure

Data preparation. Transcripts for the eight sessions were available from the previous studies. Client verbal behavior was unitized (divided into grammatical sentences) by two trained judges using rules in Hill et al. (1981). These two judges had a 92% agreement rate for unitizing. Unitizing discrepancies were discussed until agreement was reached on consensus units.

CBS judgment process. Judgments were made in a two-step process of first judging response units (grammatical sentences) and then judging predominant behaviors (in speaking turns). Using videotapes and transcripts of a session, the judges independently assigned each response unit (grammatical sentence) to one category of the CBS. Interjudge agreement was calculated on these independent judgments. After completing all judgments for a session, judges met to resolve discrepancies. Any units in which fewer than three of the four judges agreed on the categorization were discussed until a consensus judgment was achieved. Once consensus judgments were reached for all units within a speaking turn (everything a client said between two counselor speeches), judges independently coded the predominant (major, primary) behavior for that speaking turn. In the occasional event that a behavioral shift resulted in two categories predominating in a turn, the behavior that came early in the turn (in response to the counselor's speaking turn) was weighed as most important in making the predominant judgment. When fewer than three judges agreed on the predominant categorization, judges discussed their judgments until they reached a consensus.

We should note that the rules used to define predominant judgments could differ on the basis of the research question. We used the rule of attending more to the initial part of the speaking turn in the occasional instances in which a shift in client behavior resulted in more than one predominant category. We weighed the initial portion more heavily because we conceptualized client responses as occurring in response to counselor interventions. If future researchers were more interested in examining client behavior as a stimulus for counselor interventions, they could weigh the latter portion of the speaking turn more heavily.

Results

Reliability

Response units. We expected interjudge agreement to be somewhat low because of the difficulty in discriminating client

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behaviors, so we used four rather than the more typical two or three judges. Use of more judges should allow for a more reliable estimate of the "true" judgment. The kappa statistic, generally regarded as the most appropriate index of agreement between judges because it corrects for chance (Tinsley & Weiss, 1975), is used with pairs of judges and therefore does not reflect the advantage of using additional judges. Because of this problem with kappa values, we present both the average number of judges who agreed on their independent judgments and kappa values.

Table 2 shows that an average of 3.26 judges agreed on categorizations, indicating high agreement levels. The average kappa value between pairs of judges was .54 (SD = 0.02), which according to Fleiss (1981) is fair to good agreement.

More than three judges usually agreed on categorizations for agreement, requests, recounting, and cognitive–behavioral exploration, whereas fewer than three judges usually agreed on categorizations for resistance, affective exploration, insight, and changes. Thus, these latter categories appeared to be more difficult to judge.

To determine areas of difficulty in judging among categories, we constructed a confusion matrix by plotting the categorizations for each judge against the categorization of every other judge (e.g., one judge coded Category 1, whereas another judge coded Category 4). Thus, we could examine which categories were most likely to be confused with other categories (i.e., the area of most disagreement among judges). Because the matrix was an overlay of categorizations of each response unit for six pairs of judges, this matrix was simply examined for patterns of overlap between categories. Our criterion for examining the table was to note whether judgments of the other seven categories occurred about as often as judgments of the same category. Cognitive–behavioral exploration overlapped with resistance, recounting, affective exploration, and insight; resistance overlapped with recounting.

Predominant categorizations. Table 2 reveals that overall an average of 3.84 judges agreed on the predominant categorizations, again indicating high agreement levels. The average kappa between pairs of judges was 0.92 (SD = 0.01), which according to Fleiss (1981) indicates strong agreement. In addition, more than three judges agreed on the categorizations for each category. Examination of the confusion matrix indicated no major overlap among categories.

Proportions of Client Behavior System Categories

Table 3 presents the means and standard deviations for the proportions of the eight CBS categories for categorizations on both response units and predominant judgments. The most frequently occurring category for response units was recounting (49%), whereas the most frequently occurring category for predominant judgments was cognitive–behavioral exploration (39%). In the remaining analyses, we use the predominant judgments.

Client Behavior System Categories and Experiencing Ratings

Table 4 shows the means and standard deviations of the experiencing ratings for each CBS category. We conducted an analysis of variance (ANOVA), with the main effects of case and predominant judgments on the eight CBS categories, using experiencing ratings as the dependent variable. Case was included as a main effect to control for the effects of eight different cases but was not interpreted. Thus, we determined the effects of CBS categories on experiencing independent of case differences. Controlling for case, a significant effect was found for the predominant CBS categories, $F(7, 609) = 14.25$, $p < .001$. Post hoc comparisons between all pairs of CBS categories, with Tukey's Studentized range test, which controlled for the Type I experimentwise error rate, indicated that affective exploration and insight were associated with higher experiencing levels than resistance, requests, agree-

Table 2
Average Number of Judges Agreeing on Categories of the Client Behavior System for Response Unit and Predominant (Speaking Turn) Judgments for Study 1 and Study 2

	Study 1				Study 2			
	Unit		Predominant		Unit		Predominant	
Category	*M*	*SD*	*M*	*SD*	*M*	*SD*	*M*	*SD*
Resistance	2.37	0.92	3.91	0.34	2.61	0.94	3.50	0.75
Agreement	3.13	0.92	3.92	0.36	—	—	—	—
Request	3.27	0.80	3.94	0.25	3.69	0.63	—	—
Recounting	3.52	0.73	3.94	0.27	3.36	0.80	3.68	0.65
Cog–beh exploration	3.22	0.74	3.83	0.46	3.12	0.75	3.59	0.64
Affective exploration	2.78	1.03	3.62	0.78	2.96	1.01	3.56	0.63
Insight	2.51	0.94	3.85	0.46	2.32	0.99	3.33	0.58
Changes	2.61	1.16	3.57	0.76	1.78	0.90	3.40	0.55
Total	3.26	0.85	3.86	0.43	3.21	0.84	3.61	0.65

Note. Cog–beh = cognitive–behavioral. Four judges categorized each unit or speaking turn (predominant judgment). In Study 2, dashes indicate that no categorizations were made in the agreement category for response units or in the agreement or requests categories for the predominant judgments.

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Table 3
Proportions of Client Behavior System Categories for Eight Clients in Study 1

Categories	Unit *M*	Unit *SD*	Predominant *M*	Predominant *SD*
Resistance	.08	.05	.11	.07
Agreement	.03	.01	.06	.04
Request	.01	.01	.03	.01
Recounting	.49	.15	.30	.12
Cog–beh exploration	.33	.11	.39	.08
Affective exploration	.03	.02	.06	.02
Insight	.03	.02	.05	.05
Changes	.02	.01	.11	.07

Note. Cog–beh = cognitive–behavioral.

ment, recounting, and cognitive–behavioral exploration (changes fell in between).

Client Behavior System Categories and Client Helpfulness Ratings

Table 4 also shows the means and standard deviations for client ratings of the helpfulness of therapist interventions that preceded each CBS category of client behavior. We conducted an ANOVA, with the main effects of case (included to control for the effects of the eight different cases) and the predominant judgments on the eight CBS categories, using client helpfulness ratings as the dependent variable. Controlling for case, a significant effect was found for the predominant CBS categories, $F(7, 639) = 6.21$, $p = .0001$. Post hoc comparisons between all pairs of CBS categories with Tukey's Studentized range test (to control for the Type I experimentwise error rate) indicated that interventions preceding resistance and cognitive–behavioral exploration were rated as more helpful than interventions preceding recounting (agreement, requests, affective exploration, insight, and changes fell in between).

Table 4
Average Client Experiencing and Helpfulness Ratings for Each Predominant Categorization on the Client Behavior System in Study 1

Category	Experiencing Scale *M*	Experiencing Scale *SD*	Helpfulness Scale *M*	Helpfulness Scale *SD*
Resistance	2.10	0.31_b	6.79	1.22_a
Agreement	2.00	0.00_b	6.55	1.47_{ab}
Request	2.06	0.25_b	6.26	1.05_{ab}
Recounting	2.19	0.48_b	6.12	1.35_b
Cog–beh exploration	2.26	0.53_b	6.69	1.23_a
Affective exploration	2.88	0.40_a	6.69	1.28_a
Insight	2.59	0.91_a	6.31	1.95_{ab}
Changes	2.47	0.62_{ab}	6.76	1.56_{ab}

Note. Cog–beh = cognitive–behavioral. The Experiencing Scale is a 7-point scale ranging from *low experiencing* (1) to *high experiencing* (7); the Helpfulness Scale is a 9-point scale ranging from *extremely unhelpful* (1) to *extremely helpful* (9). In each column, categories with the same subscripts are not significantly different from each other (e.g., a and b are significantly different, whereas a and ab are not significantly different).

Discussion

The psychometric properties of the CBS appear to be adequate. We were able to establish reliability (in terms of interjudge agreement levels), convergent validity with client experiencing ratings, and construct validity with client ratings of the helpfulness of preceding counselor interventions.

We contend that it is most appropriate to examine the predominant client behavior during a speaking turn, which most likely is what counselors respond to in sessions. Agreement levels were higher for predominant judgments than for unit judgments, which was probably partially due to the procedure of making predominant judgments after discussing unit judgments. After judges independently judged all units within a speaking turn, they discussed their judgments until a consensus was reached and then independently judged the predominant client behavior. Use of linked judgments is somewhat problematic in terms of the independence of judgments, but other methods of obtaining predominant judgments, such as using separate teams of judges, are even more problematic in that judges might not agree on the behavior in the initial units.

Examination of the predominant behaviors in our sample (Table 3) indicates that we were able to describe a more complete range of client behavior than the earlier Hill et al. (1981) system. Whereas the majority of the comparable responses obtained with the earlier Hill et al. system were in the description category (Hill et al., 1983; O'Farrell et al., 1986), four categories accounted for the majority of the responses obtained with the CBS: cognitive–behavioral exploration (39%), recounting (30%), resistance (11%), and changes (11%). Thus, it appears that we were able to separate the large category of description into the important therapeutic behaviors of resistance, recounting, and cognitive–behavioral exploration. Separating the behaviors yielded a lower interjudge agreement level than Hill et al. had achieved but provides a better description of client behavior.

We were particularly pleased to see that resistance accounted for 11% of the total client behavior, given the significance of resistance in counseling (Chamberlain et al., 1984; Chamberlain & Ray, 1988; Patterson & Forgatch, 1985). Interjudge agreement on resistance was lower than for the other categories, however, indicating that judges found it difficult to code resistance. What seems to be defensive behavior to one judge may not appear to be defensive behavior to another judge. The key to distinguishing between resistance and other categories is often in the nonverbal and paralinguistic cues, which suggests that watching the videotape of the therapy session is essential. Problems remain, however, in differentiating resistance from other categories.

Although Chamberlain et al. (1984) specified several subtypes of resistant behaviors, we could not distinguish among these subtypes reliably in our preliminary development of the CBS. Because resistant behaviors occurred relatively infre-

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quently, we decided that it was most important simply to know that a resistant behavior occurred rather than to know the specific subtype. Therefore, we combined all of the resistant behaviors (e.g., sidetracking, complaining) into one category. Further research could clarify differences among subtypes of resistance.

To establish convergent validity, we compared the CBS categories with the Experiencing Scale (Klein et al., 1986), which has been used extensively in psychotherapy research. When clients exhibited affective exploration and insight, as compared with other CBS behaviors, they were rated by trained judges as having higher levels of experiencing. Given that the Experiencing Scale emphasizes affect and insight, these findings make sense. Interestingly, cognitive–behavioral exploration was not associated with higher levels of experiencing than recounting, perhaps because the Experiencing Scale does not discriminate among different types of nonaffective responding. We should note that scores on the Experiencing Scale were low and that the range was restricted (M = 2.31, SD = 0.15 on a 7-point scale), which may have precluded finding more relationships with the CBS categories.

To establish construct validity, we compared the CBS categorizations with client ratings of the helpfulness of the previous counselor intervention. Interventions preceding client resistance and cognitive–behavioral exploration were rated as more helpful than other interventions. Thus, when clients viewed counselor interventions as very helpful, their responses were likely to be resistant or exploratory. The results for cognitive–behavioral exploration are logical in that helpful interventions would be expected to lead to productive client work. We are somewhat surprised with the results for resistance, but we speculate that clients might resist a helpful intervention if that intervention seemed especially challenging or threatening.

Study 2

The purpose of Study 2 was to provide evidence of construct validity for the CBS with another data set. We hypothesized that interviewees would exhibit different CBS behaviors in response to different interviewer queries. We designed nine queries to elicit different CBS categories from the interviewees. The nine queries and the CBS categories that we hypothesized would be elicited are shown in Table 5.

Method

Interviewees

Thirty-nine undergraduate students (17 female, 22 male; 26 White, 5 Black, 5 Asian American, 2 Arabic American, 1 Hispanic American), ages 18–42 (M = 19.87, SD = 2.51) years, participated. The students were enrolled in psychology courses and received course credit for their participation.

Interviewers

The interviewers were the four judges from Study 1.

Judges

Two new judges (both graduate students) and two of the judges from Study 1 (a graduate student and a post-PhD professor) served

Table 5
Queries Used for Study 2, Hypothesized Client Behavior in Response to Each Query, and Actual Client Behavior in Response to Each Query

Query	Hypothesized CBS Category	Actual CBS Category
Understand: Tell me something you understand about yourself	Insight	Cognitive–behavioral exploration
Bad: Tell me something bad someone did to you	Resistance	Recounting
Decision: Tell me something you have made a decision about	Changes	Recounting
Trivial: Tell me something trivial that has happened to you recently	Recounting	Recounting
Feelings: Tell me something you have strong feelings or emotions about	Affective exploration	Cognitive–behavioral exploration
Worried: Tell me something you are worried about	Affective exploration	Affective exploration
Don't Understand: Tell me something you do but don't understand why you do it	Cognitive–behavioral exploration	Cognitive–behavioral exploration
Don't Like: Tell me something you do not like about yourself	Cognitive–behavioral exploration	Cognitive–behavioral exploration
Not Fault: Tell me something that someone blamed you for that you don't think is your fault	Resistance	Recounting

Note. CBS = Client behavior system.

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as judges. The two additional judges are also authors of the study. The new judges obtained training by practicing on three transcripts from Study 1 and comparing their judgments to consensus judgments.

Measures

The CBS, described in Study 1, was used.

Procedure

Interview. Interviewees were informed that they would be asked to talk for 3–5 min about each of several topics, that the interviewer would respond only minimally, and that sessions would be videotaped. Prior to participating, each interviewee signed a consent form. Interviewees were randomly assigned to one of the four interviewers. Interviewers were trained to respond only minimally after presenting each query so that responses would reflect the interviewee rather than the interviewer. Thus, interviewers were instructed to appear interested and to use minimal encouragers, such as "Mmhmm" but not to probe further or respond to the interviewee. If the interviewee asked about how to respond, the interviewer repeated the query and reassured the interviewee that whatever she or he wanted to say was fine. Interviewees were not held to any time restriction in their responses. The nine queries (shown in Table 5) were arranged in a different random-order sequence for each interviewee. After the interview, subjects were debriefed about the purpose of the study, allowed to ask any questions, and given referral information about the university counseling center.

Data preparation. The interviewee responses to each of the nine queries were excerpted from the videotapes of each interview. Interviewer queries were not excerpted so that judges would be unaware of the stimuli preceding the interviewee response. When interviewers responded to interviewees with more than minimal encouragers, the interviewer response and subsequent interviewee response was not excerpted, in keeping with the intent that only the interviewee response to the standard stimuli be recorded. Thus, if an interviewer reflected feelings or asked a further probing question during the interviewee's response, the response to this second intervention was not excerpted. Each excerpted session was then transcribed verbatim (excluding the interviewer queries). Because high interrater reliability had been established in Study 1, only one judge unitized (divided into grammatical sentences) the client speech in all the transcripts.

Client behavior system judgment process. The judgment process occurred several months after the interviews were done, so that even though two of the judges had also been interviewers, there was minimal chance that they would recall the specific interviewer queries preceding client responses (especially as these queries were not excerpted). Units (sentences) within sessions were categorized independently by each of the four judges into one of the CBS categories while the judges watched the videotape and read the transcript. Following independent judgments of each entire session, the judges met to discuss and resolve discrepancies. Any units in which fewer than three of the four judges agreed on the categorization were discussed until a consensus judgment was achieved. Once consensus judgments were reached for all units within a speaking turn, judges independently determined a predominant categorization for the speaking turn. When fewer than three judges agreed on the predominant categorization, judges discussed their judgments until they reached a consensus.

Results

Reliability

As in Study 1, interjudge agreement was determined by calculating both the average number of judges agreeing before discussion and the kappa value. For response units, an average of 3.21 (SD = 0.84) of 4 judges agreed across all categorizations, indicating high agreement. Average kappa values between pairs of judges was .48, indicating fair to good agreement (Fleiss, 1981). Table 2 shows that more than three judges agreed on the categorizations for requests, recounting, and cognitive–behavioral exploration, whereas fewer than three agreed on resistance, affective exploration, insight, and changes.

For predominant judgments, an average of 3.61 (SD = 0.65) judges agreed across all categorizations, and the average kappa value between pairs of judges was .59, again indicating fair to good agreement. Table 2 shows that more than three judges agreed on the categorizations for all eight categories.

Predominant Client Behavior in Response to Different Queries

The frequency of predominant responses by CBS category and query is shown in Table 6. Each query was analyzed with

Table 6
Frequency of Predominant Judgments in Each of Six Client Behavior System (CBS) Categories in Response to Nine Interview Queries in Study 2

	Interviewer Query								
CBS Category	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9
Resistance	2	7	0	6	1	1	2	1	8
Recounting	12	23	26	31	8	4	8	5	19
Cog–beh exploration	22	8	8	2	21	8	27	28	9
Affective exploration	0	1	1	0	9	25	0	5	0
Insight	1	0	0	0	0	0	2	0	0
Changes	1	0	4	0	0	0	0	0	0
N	38	39	39	39	39	38	39	39	36

Note. Cog–beh = Cognitive–behavioral; Interviewer Query 1 = Understand, 2 = Bad, 3 = Decision, 4 = Trivial, 5 = Feelings, 6 = Worried, 7 = Don't Understand, 8 = Don't Like, 9 = Not Fault. The CBS categories of agreement and requests were never coded as predominant.

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a separate chi-square analysis because each interviewee received all nine queries and chi-square analyses require independent data within cells. The assumption underlying the chi-square analyses was that each client behavior was equally likely to occur in response to the interviewer query. Because agreement and appropriate requests never occurred in the predominant judgments, only six categories were examined for these analyses. The sample size is slightly different for some of the analyses because interviewers occasionally forgot to ask a question.

The overall chi-square values for all nine queries were significant at the .05 level: for Category 1, $\chi^2(5, N = 38) = 62.44$; for Category 2, $\chi^2(5, N = 39) = 59.92$; for Category 3, $\chi^2(5, N = 39) = 77.46$; for Category 4, $\chi^2(5, N = 39) = 115.35$; for Category 5, $\chi^2(5, N = 39) = 38.31$; for Category 6, $\chi^2(5, N = 38) = 73.87$; for Category 7, $\chi^2(5, N = 39) = 86.15$; for Category 8, $\chi^2(5, N = 39) = 89.47$; and for Category 9, $\chi^2(5, N = 36) = 48.34$. Because of the lack of independence between queries, results of the chi-square analyses across the queries could not be compared.

Cell chi-square tests were conducted to determine which behaviors occurred more or less often than chance for each query. Because six separate cell chi-square tests were conducted for each query, a Bonferroni-adjusted alpha of .001 was used (critical value = 10.8). Cell chi-square tests indicated that interviewees responded with the following behaviors more often than chance: recounting to the queries labeled bad, decision, trivial, and not fault; cognitive–behavioral exploration to queries labeled understand, feelings, don't understand, and don't like; and affective exploration to the query labeled worried (See Table 5).

Discussion

Different standard interviewer queries resulted in different client behavior. Evidence for construct validity is provided by the findings that different client behaviors were elicited by different interviewer queries.

As predicted, interviewees most often responded with recounting when interviewers asked them to talk about something trivial that had happened to them. Interviewees did tend to tell a story about some recent event, although interestingly a certain number indicated that nothing trivial ever happened to them. Contrary to our predictions, interviewees also responded with recounting when interviewers asked them to talk about something bad that had happened to them, something someone blamed them for that was not their fault, or a decision they had made. We had predicted that interviewees would respond to the first two queries with resistance and to the third with changes. Perhaps in a brief, structured interview, interviewees are more likely to respond cautiously and superficially (with recounting) than they would in a more emotionally provocative situation.

Additionally, as predicted, interviewees responded with cognitive–behavioral exploration when interviewers asked them to talk about something they did not understand about themselves and something they did not like about themselves. Contrary to expectation, when the interviewer asked the interviewee to talk about something about which they had strong feelings or emotions, interviewees responded with cognitive–behavioral exploration rather than affective exploration. Rather than exploring some feeling or emotion, interviewees typically talked about some issue on which they had definite opinions, such as abortion or feelings about gay men and lesbians. Also contrary to our expectations, interviewees responded with cognitive–behavioral exploration rather than insight when interviewers asked them to talk about something they understood about themselves. Perhaps without the stimulus of the interviewer helping them achieve insight, it was difficult for these people to gain insights about themselves.

Furthermore, as predicted, interviewees responded with affective exploration to the query of what they were worried about. Interestingly, affective exploration occurred much more often in response to the request to discuss something that worried participants than it did in ongoing therapy (see Study 1). Our sense is that counselors typically reflect feelings but seldom ask a direct question about a specific feeling in counseling. These results are reminiscent of the findings of Hill and Gormally (1977) that probes for feelings elicited more client affect than did reflections of feelings or restatements.

We were not able to elicit resistance, insight, or therapeutic changes at a level greater than chance to any of the questions. These are all behaviors that may be less likely to occur in brief structured interviews than in ongoing counseling, in which there is more interaction between the counselor and client.

Interjudge agreement was lower in Study 2 than in Study 1, particularly for the predominant judgments. One explanation for the low agreement level was that it was more difficult to judge behavior in these brief structured interviews than in therapy. In the interviews, interviewees engaged in long speaking turns, which make it more difficult to determine a predominant behavior. Furthermore, interviewees did not engage in the CBS categories of minimal resistance, agreement, or insight. When they did engage in cognitive–behavioral or affective exploration, it was seldom as deep as occurred in actual therapy, making it more difficult for judges to distinguish these categories from recounting.

General Conclusions

The CBS, the revised version of the earlier Hill et al. (1981) Client Verbal Response Category System, appears to have adequate validity and reliability. Several of the problems with the earlier version have been corrected: (a) Categories of cognitive–behavioral exploration and resistance have been included to make the CBS more comprehensive and pantheoretical; (b) the CBS incorporates nonverbal and paralinguistic cues in the definitions of the categories and requires observation of the videotapes of sessions; (c) predominant judgments are used instead of unit (sentence) judgments; and (d) categories at different levels of abstraction (minimal encourager, silence, and discussion of the client–counselor relationship) were dropped.

Determining the superiority of the revised system over the previous system is difficult. The interjudge agreement levels are lower, seemingly because of the addition of more clinically

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meaningful but difficult to differentiate categories. The categories from the new system operate as we expected them to operate for the most part, providing evidence for construct validity. Thus, we assert that the new version is superior from a validity perspective.

Although the interjudge agreement levels fall within the fair-to-good range, they are not as high as we would like them to be. We attribute this to the difficulty in categorizing client behavior. In contrast to judgment of counselor behavior for which there are identifiable discrete techniques, clients are not as likely to engage in discrete, differentiated tasks. For example, resistance, recounting, and cognitive–behavioral exploration seem to be qualitatively rather than structurally distinct. Although difficulties in distinguishing client behavior may be part of the reason why client behavior measures are not as well developed as therapist behavior measures, we need to keep struggling to define client behaviors so that we can study client change in counseling.

The CBS can be used in several ways in future research. First, the measure could be used as an index of the context in which counselor interventions are delivered. Second, the measure could be used as an index of the immediate outcome of counselor interventions, providing an assessment of the ways in which clients respond to different interventions. Third, the CBS could be used to describe client behavior as well as client change both within and across the course of sessions. If counselor interventions have an effect on clients, then there ought to be a change in client behavior over the course of therapy. For example, as a result of therapy, clients might engage in more exploration and insight, behaviors that counselors often consider desirable.

As is true for all counseling process measures, several methodological procedures need to be examined for the CBS: the necessary level of experience of judges (Moras & Hill, 1991), the potential for bias due to judges' personality characteristics or perceived similarity with clients (Mahalik, Hill, O'Grady, & Thompson, in press), and the most appropriate methods for training judges (cf. Hill, 1991; Lambert & Hill, in press). Furthermore, interjudge agreement levels need to be tested with other sets of judges.

In sum, the CBS provides a promising alternative to other measures of client in-session behavior. Additionally, this measure completes the battery of instruments needed to test a process model of counseling and psychotherapy, which includes counselor intentions, counselor response modes, client reactions, and client behaviors (Hill, 1992; Hill & O'Grady, 1985). We hope that this model can now be tested more completely to determine how faithfully it describes the therapy process.

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Appendix

The Client Behavior System

Instructions

Client behavior should be judged by trained judges using both videotapes and transcripts. Minimal verbalizations (such as "Mmhmm" or "yeah") and silence are not coded within this system. Events such as role-playing, problem-solving, dream reports, or guided fantasies should be judged for the client behaviors exhibited during each response unit and speaking turn within the event. Each client response unit (grammatical sentence) and speaking turn (called a predominant judgment) should be assigned to *one* category. With predominant judgments, judges should decide in advance (depending on the research question) to either weight the initial or latter portion of the speaking turn most heavily when there is a shift of emphasis or topic.

Categories

Resistance

Includes complaining or blaming others inappropriately, defenses (e.g., projection, denial, intellectualization, avoidance, dissociation, etc.), sidetracking (changing the topic), and inappropriate requests (reflecting excessive helplessness or dependency). Resistant behavior tends to block progress in therapy and is often used to suggest that the client cannot change. These statements may be used by clients to protect themselves from an abusive or hostile therapist. The client's tone of voice is often defensive, whiny, defeated, abusive, or hostile.

Agreement

Indicates understanding or approval of what the therapist has said without adding substantially to the therapist's statement. Must be more than a simple response (e.g., "Mmhmm" or "yeah") that serves to maintain conversation.

Appropriate Request

An attempt to obtain clarification, understanding, information, or advice from the therapist. If client acts helpless or overly dependent, code as resistance.

Recounting

Small talk or statements that answer questions or give factual information about past events. Client reports in a storytelling style (e.g., "I said. . ., he said. . ., then I said") rather than actively and presently exploring feelings and thoughts or interacting and working with the therapist. Tone of voice tends to be monotonic or conversational with minimal involvement in the immediate moment.

Cognitive–Behavioral Exploration

Statements that indicate the client is currently involved and exploring therapeutically significant thoughts or behaviors. Clients exhibit a quality of actively thinking about their issues, which typically indicates that they do not have all the answers and are exploring to understand more. Disagreeing with or challenging the therapist would be coded here if clients are actively exploring their own thoughts or behaviors. In general, this category is not coded when a client is talking about another person *unless* understanding that person's behavior has a significant implication for the client. Voice tone tends to have a lot of energy and to be irregular with pauses and thoughtfulness.

Affective Exploration

Statements that indicate that the client is currently involved and exploring feelings about therapeutically significant material. Specific feeling words must be stated (e.g., happy, sad, anxious), or clearly visible nonverbal behavior (e.g., audible sighs, clenched fists, lowering of the head, crying or shifting body position) must accompany affective material. The client's voice must sound as if feelings are being experienced in the present moment. Discussion of past feelings would be coded as recounting unless the client is reexperiencing the feelings in the present moment. Disagreeing with or challenging the therapist would be coded here if clients are actively exploring their feelings.

Insight

Client expresses an understanding of something about himself or herself and can articulate patterns or reasons for behaviors, thoughts,

or feelings. Insight usually involves an "aha" experience, in which the client perceives himself/herself or his/her world in a new way. The client takes appropriate responsibility rather than blaming others, using "shoulds" imposed from the outside world, or rationalizing (Note: these behaviors would be coded as resistance).

Therapeutic Changes

Client expresses changes in his or her own behaviors, thoughts, and/or feelings in therapeutically significant areas. Changes can be increases in positive target areas, decreases in negative areas, or indications of action-oriented plans or decisions. If client reports changes, but no change is apparent to judges, code as resistance.

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